

Autistics working in academia: What are the barriers and facilitators?

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Abstract

Autistic people are under-represented in university student populations, but their numbers are growing, and the barriers to their inclusion are being recognised. Outside of the student body, autistic people in academia are often overlooked, although this is starting to change with the growth in inclusive autism research. However, they remain absent from the academic literature, despite the evident synergies between autistic strengths and academic careers. This study explored the perceptions of 37 autistic academics from various disciplines: what are the positives of working in academia for autistic people, and what are the negatives? Participants reported many positive aspects of an academic career, including the fit with the strengths, characteristics and motivations of autistic people. However, they also noted barriers and challenges – social, environmental and structural – many of which could be addressed by greater awareness and acceptance of autism. Given the considerable benefits that autistic teachers and researchers bring to higher education, there is a clear need for universities and colleges to implement changes to the physical and social environment to make academia more inclusive.

Lay Abstract

Academia appears to provide an ideal career option for autistic people: the opportunity to lock ourselves away in an ivory tower and utilise our extensive knowledge of a very specific topic. We know autistic people are underrepresented in postsecondary education, and there is a growing body of research on how to make universities more inclusive. What is missing from the literature is the voices of autistic people who have survived the university experience and gone on to become university teachers and researchers. Increasing the visibility of autistics in academia, and exploring the barriers and facilitators they experience in an academic career, is important to raise the aspirations of future university students and graduates. This study included 37 autistic academics from various disciplines and countries, exploring their perceptions of the positive and negative aspects of being an autistic in academia.

Keywords

employment, higher education, lived experience

There is a growing body of literature on the experiences of autistic students in higher education. This includes research into rates and predictors of postsecondary education enrolment (Chiang et al., 2012; Flower et al., 2021), and reasons for discontinuing university studies (Cage & Howes, 2020). Aspects of educational experiences, needs and support provisions have been examined (Cai & Richdale, 2016; Chandrasekhar, 2020; Elias & White, 2018; McLeod et al., 2019), as well as the social experiences of autistic university students, including interaction and exclusion (Goddard & Cook, 2022; Gurbuz et al., 2019), social

supports, networks and anxiety (Lei et al., 2019, 2020) and experiences of bullying (DeNigris et al., 2018).

What is surprisingly absent from the literature is research on the experiences of autistic people *working* in

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academia; that is, those who have completed graduate studies and embarked on a research and/or teaching career. This is in part due to the long history of autism research centred in a pathology paradigm (Walker & Raymaker, 2020), with autistic people seen as inferior and disordered. Such a paradigm promulgates the belief that advances in our understanding of autism and how to support autistic people will come from neurotypical researchers, and minimises the contribution of autistic people to ‘end-users’ rather than generators of knowledge. It also promulgates the assumption that autistic people will not be present in higher education and that those ‘rare few’ who are must be ‘less autistic’, and the associated stigma deters those who are working in academia from disclosing.

As Milton et al. (2019) note in their reflection on the establishment of the Participatory Autism Research Collective and the issues facing autistic individuals working in the autism field, ‘. . . we are aware of a vast array of issues that we share and with which we need support. These may apply more broadly to many autistic autism professionals and/or activists but are contextualised in a different way within academia’ (p. 86). If we are to encourage more autistic individuals to undertake education and training to become researchers and thus have an equal space at the table with non-autistic researchers, we need to understand what aspects of the role and environment are conducive to (and what presents barriers to) autistic individuals succeeding in the academy.

Recently we have seen a small number of papers reflecting on ways that academia could be more inclusive and supportive for autistic people, typically from the perspective of an autistic scholar contemplating their experiences. For example, Taylor and Johnson (2020) reflect on the first author’s experiences as a doctoral student in geosciences and suggest ways that the field could be more inclusive; and Raymaker (2017) reflects on being an insider-researcher in a community-based participatory research setting.

Going beyond the experiences of one individual, Martin (2021) reports on a questionnaire study that explored the experiences of 12 autistic researchers (doctoral students, part-time researchers and other non-permanent roles) and ‘revealed barriers at every stage of the employment journey for autistic academics and highlighted relatively straightforward ways of circumventing them based on principles of Universal Design’ (p. 14). A recent autistic autism researchers’ roundtable (Dwyer et al., 2021) reflected on several topics, including the importance of autistic and intersectional identities, ways in which autistic autism researchers can enhance the quality of autism research, tensions and conflicts that we face as autistic autism researchers, and ways in which inflexible institutions and practices can impose barriers that restrict autistic involvement in academia.

The purpose of this study was to explore the perspectives and experiences of autistic individuals working in

academia across various disciplines on the benefits and barriers to pursuing a career in the academy.

Method

Participants and procedure

This study formed part of a larger longitudinal project conducted across 12 months and involving 37 autistic academics (defined as working in, or having recently worked in, a university in a teaching and/or research and/or governance role). Participants were recruited via the promotion of the study on social media and through word of mouth. The social media posts directed interested individuals to a website that provided study details, a downloadable consent form and an email address for study enrolment.

Each month, participants were invited via email to provide a written reflection on a specific topic, and although prompts were provided, participants were encouraged to write about any aspect of the topic that was of interest or relevance to them. Participation for each topic was optional; however, participants were only included in the sample if they completed and returned the consent form, statistical data sheet and at least four reflections. Twenty-eight participants (72%) completed all 12 monthly reflections, 31 at least nine and 33 at least six.

In January 2021, participants were invited to provide a written reflection on the topic of ‘Being an Autistic in Academia’ and all 37 participants (100%) returned a reflection, ranging in length from 189 to 2965 words ($x=1081$). This invitation prompted them to reflect on negative aspects of employment in academia (What challenges do you experience in your job? What do you like the least about your job?) and positive aspects (What do you like the most about your job?).

All participants were either currently working in academia ($n=26$), had previously worked in academia ($n=7$) and/or were undertaking doctoral studies ($n=12$), with period of employment in academia ranging from 1 to 23 years. The majority had a formal autism diagnosis ($n=32$); 21 identified as female, nine as male and seven as non-binary. Participants resided in Australia ($n=13$), the United States ($n=11$), Canada ($n=5$), the United Kingdom ($n=5$), New Zealand and continental Europe. Participants came from various disciplines, including creative arts, education, engineering, health, languages, leadership, psychology, sciences, social sciences and sociology.

Data analysis

Reflections were saved into a consistent format and imported into NVivo for coding. An inductive approach to data analysis was utilised, following Braun and Clarke’s approach to reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2019). This approach was chosen because the

aim of the study was to understand the benefits and challenges of autistic people working in universities, as *they* experience them. Consistent with the author's position as an 'insider researcher' this paradigm recognises that the researcher's own lived experiences will influence interpretation of the data.

The analysis process was iterative, with initial codes created and a visual map produced to identify overlapping and intersecting codes. Following a close reading of all transcripts, each transcript was coded line by line with initial codes generated as new concepts or ideas were identified. This resulted in a total of 117 initial codes. The codes were then refined and merged with constant reference to the content of each lower-order code, and constant updating of the visual map. Based on a thorough review of all codes and their content, 11 provisional themes were generated. These were further refined and combined to eliminate overlapping themes and ensure that all included text was relevant to the overarching theme, resulting in a total of five themes.

Data were anonymised, with participants providing their preferred pseudonyms for analysis and reporting. The results were shared with all participants to ensure that the interpretation aligned with their reflections and lived experience.

Researcher positionality

The researcher is a late-diagnosed autistic woman, parent of two autistic people, autism advocate and experienced autism researcher. She has been working in academia for more than 20 years as a researcher, manager and senior administrator. While she did not know the participants personally, the in-depth nature of the study means she was privy to their thoughts and perspectives on a range of very personal issues; the ongoing nature of the study meant that she interacted with them regularly via email. She also identified with many of their perspectives and was struck by the similarity of their experiences to her own as an autistic in academia.

Community involvement statement

This research was conducted entirely by autistic people. The author is an autistic autism researcher. A panel of four autistic people reviewed the data collection tools for clarity, comprehensiveness and inclusive language; these individuals were working as researchers and/or undertaking doctoral studies and did not participate in the study. All study participants are autistic.

Results

The five themes the author generated from the analysis of reflections on the positives and negatives of autistic people

working in academia are discussed below in order of their prominence within the data and the emphasis placed on these issues in the reflections.

Social interaction is complicated

The complexities of social interaction and the challenges it poses for working in academia, including the energy required for constant masking of autistic traits to 'fit in', dominated this theme. Enormous amounts of emotional energy are required to manage the nature and frequency of social interactions, both 'work-based' interactions such as meetings and 'social-based' interactions. Understanding and following social rules, interpreting others' actions and reactions, masking autistic behaviours, and combining 'professional' and 'personal' interactions are effortful activities for many autistic people. Aspects that non-autistic people find relaxing and enjoyable (such as morning teas and after-work drinks) can be very challenging for autistic people. Participants frequently mentioned the sheer number of meetings that take place each day in academia as a difficult aspect of academic roles. In addition to the energy required to participate in the conversation, frustrations arise around the management of meetings and the time that is wasted when there are more efficient ways of achieving outcomes.

The transient nature of academia adds to the intensity of the effort required to maintain social interaction. While we may have a consistent group of colleagues (as in other professions), the academic year brings new cohorts of students, and conferences and meetings bring new 'colleagues'. Some participants also noted having prosopagnosia (face blindness), a more common condition among autistic people (Minio-Paluello et al., 2020), and the additional challenges this brings to social interactions.

I also find some social aspects of the job to be tricky; sometimes it's easy to connect with others over shared interests, but I'm often unsure how to read a situation. And again, with new classes and new work assignments every semester, I'm constantly having to navigate new groups of people and figure out how we're going to work together. (Dee)

Social interactions take time and energy that is needed to complete work, creating an ever-present need to balance the work we are paid to do with the social expectations of colleagues. The tendency of autistic people to be intensely focused on the activity they are engaged in can be mistaken for rudeness or hostility. A lack of assertiveness and difficulties with spontaneous communication can be mistaken for disinterest or lower capacity. For some participants, this social aspect went beyond the energy requirements of social interaction; they also had the worry of exclusion or hostility from colleagues. The political nature of the workplace was a common topic of reflection

concerning the challenges of academia: understanding the hierarchical structure of the organisation, the nuances of power and alliances and the need to intuit the hidden meaning behind communications.

I know that I simply don't have the skills or the capacity to play those nuanced neurotypical games of interpersonal snakes and ladders, and most of the time I'm completely unaware that they're even going on. . . . I know that I'm likely missing out on opportunities because I'm not able to access the social politics of academia, and that's sometimes frustrating. (Alex)

The tendency of autistic people to be honest and direct, to be uncomfortable with deception and unable to detect deception in others can put us at a distinct disadvantage in a work context that is fundamentally competitive. There is constant competition for positions, funding, promotion and – sadly – like high school, there is competition for social status. The interaction between the politics that appear to be inherent in academia and some of the intrinsic aspects of autism (anxiety, perseveration, perfectionism) results in strain on some autistics working in academia, with negative outcomes that extend beyond the workplace.

Frustration with the lack of commitment and competence of others in the workplace – both colleagues and students – was evident in many of the reflections. Those who place high expectations on themselves and work hard to achieve these find it difficult to understand and accept the lackadaisical attitude of others.

I really hate it when I delegate a task to someone and then when I look at it, it has mistakes in it or they haven't formatted it consistently. Also it really annoys me when people can't do basic things then they ask me to do it – I only know how to do things because I have taken the time to understand how things work, have experimented and figured things out for myself. (Olivia)

It would be easy to assume that these social challenges are only experienced by those in the early stages of their career, but similar themes were evident in the reflections of participants with lengthy careers in academia and those in leadership roles.

However, the participants' reflections also emphasised great enjoyment and satisfaction in aspects of interpersonal interactions, particularly those that provide opportunities to help others. This was particularly evident in the context of sharing their knowledge with others, which was seen as the highlight of teaching roles. This went beyond the direct transmission of knowledge, reflecting not the stereotype of 'info-dumping' on others, but the value of sharing information in a way that helps others learn. As Lisa expressed it, 'Imparting large amounts of insight to smart students fast, giving them the tools to

navigate the world better once they get out there'. Equally evident in the reflections was that a positive aspect of teaching for autistic academics is the ability to help students. Participants commented on the enjoyment of watching students succeed, whether this was the short-term success of completing an assignment, or the longer-term completion of a research degree or commencement of employment. This was particularly the case in relation to assisting students who experience marginalisation and/or disadvantage.

. . . student's face when they finally get something after they've been struggling to understand it. (i.e. 'light bulb' moment) spec con student finally completing subject or sitting exam, etc. (Jane)

Many participants reflected that a strong motivator and positive aspect of working in academia was the ability to help others and make positive changes in the world. Academia can provide an opportunity to undertake meaningful research and advocacy and to fight for social justice, an area of importance for many autistic people. This included those working in the autism field – contributing to improved outcomes for autistic people – and those working in other fields that enable them to contribute to the wellbeing of people who experience marginalisation and/or disadvantage.

I love the opportunity this work gives me to make a difference in people's lives and create systems change that could make the world better for the next generations of autistic people and people with other disabilities or intersectional identities. (Sunny)

There's a lot to juggle

Various aspects of working in academia are widely acknowledged as challenging for all neurotypes but are exacerbated for autistics. These include job insecurity, low salary compared to many other careers, demanding workload and the competitive nature of academic environments. Other aspects of the role that can be exacting for autistic people include rigid processes, breadth of activity, lack of autonomy and 'performance' standards.

The lack of job security inherent in the role of early career researcher or teacher is problematic for people who struggle with uncertainty and change. The casual nature of the workforce means that there is ongoing uncertainty for those who do not have tenure. Numerous participants commented on aspects of their autism that exacerbate, or are exacerbated by, their ability to manage the heavy workload of academia. The former included underlying generalised anxiety, perfectionism and information processing. The latter included environmental, social and communication challenges. While many participants reported meeting or exceeding the expectations

of their colleagues and supervisors, this was achieved at a considerable cost to their physical and mental health.

I am a perfectionist (which could be seen as both a strength and a weakness). As such students often comment on how well delivered or presented my topics are, however this leads to me burning out and experiencing extreme anxiety and overwhelm (usually around Sept/Oct each year). (Scarlett)

Rigid processes and protocols present challenges for autistic people working in academia, particularly the adherence to inefficient or inappropriate rules and processes. Related to this is the frustration for autistics when they have identified alternative processes that would improve productivity and increase the quality of outcomes. Participants noted the *lack of autonomy* in academia as a challenge, particularly those in administrative roles and junior members of research and/or teaching teams. However, some participants noted that challenges in academia also come from too much autonomy when this is operationalised as a lack of clear direction. While there is a focus on specialisation in many areas of academia, there is also a *breadth of activity* required and an expectation of a broad range of skills assumed to be inherent in people employed in academia.

One of the challenges of academia is that it requires one be competent in many areas – one can't specialize and focus only on one or two little domains where one is especially skilled. One needs to be able to network, write papers, understand and implement research methods, hire and supervise other people, etc. (Scott)

Participants reflected on the *performance* aspect of the academic role in the context of conference presentations, media interviews and other forms of public speaking. However, it was of particular concern in teaching. While the transmission of knowledge is one of the most enjoyed aspects of academia for this cohort, the social dimensions of teaching can be draining because the onus of communication is on the autistic person who is there to educate and entertain.

...as a professor I am not much of a performer. I am excited by the work and by talking about it, but I am not flashy. I am not charismatic. I have been told that I'm intimidating. I go out of my way to be warm and friendly, but it doesn't come naturally. Students seem to expect entertainment as much as education these days, and I am not a natural entertainer. (Saskia)

Positive aspects of the academic's role reflected on by participants included flexibility and autonomy. References to flexibility included the flexibility of where to work, particularly the option to work at home; when to work, including the ability to schedule work around energy levels; and how to work, notably the flexibility around how and how often to engage in social interaction. The flexible nature of

many roles in academia provides opportunities to control when and where participants complete their work.

You can work from home and work by yourself a lot of the time, while still maintaining some degree of social interaction for teaching or meetings. (Amy)

Other aspects of autonomy that participants highly valued include the capacity to make their own decisions, focus on areas of research and/or teaching of interest to them and work in ways that suit their cognitive processes and sensory needs. Additional positive aspects of academic roles discussed in the reflections included the potential for career progression and job stability, being able to follow a routine, visible indicators of success such as winning grants or having papers published and employment conditions such as generous leave provisions and superannuation.

We have different operating systems

Differences in information processing processes and styles pose challenges in the predominantly neurotypical workplace of academia. These included learning styles, information processing speed, dealing with change, variations in information processing capacity and information synthesis.

Numerous participants reflected on being a visual learner in a context where information is often presented verbally with no visual aids, such as in conferences and meetings. Working in a context where speed of information processing can be paramount was identified as a challenge. Academic environments often value rapid responses – whether that involves a snappy answer to a question or fast-paced marking of assessments. For people who process information carefully and conscientiously, with a focus on determining the most articulate response, this expectation can result in missing out on opportunities or not being heard. The frequency of change in the academic environment and the related expectation that we will be able to absorb and implement changes rapidly create considerable stress for this autistic cohort.

Some commented on the apparent paradox of understanding and working with complex information that others grapple with while struggling to process fundamental concepts that appear intuitive to others. Similarly, participants reflected on difficulties in identifying key points of information, separating the detail from the big picture and knowing where to focus energy. This included aspects of the academic role such as reading literature, writing for publication, reviewing others' writing and preparing lectures.

I struggle to focus with writing. *Everything* is important about a topic, because it wouldn't be what it is without all the details. So the advice when publishing in my discipline to 'tell us what's important, not what you know' is pretty much impossible. (Liam)

Executive functioning challenges interact with the complex nature of academic roles. Reflections included issues of managing deadlines and requirements, organising data, staying on top of tasks, remembering things that need to be done, initiating activities, switching between activities and maintaining focus. A common issue was being in a role that required working on multiple projects simultaneously and the cognitive load involved in managing the range of tasks, competing deadlines and different task requirements. All participants who mentioned executive functioning challenges also outlined the strategies they have put in place to address them, including writing copious lists, setting up calendar reminders and using a range of physical and electronic organisation tools. Some compensated for executive functioning limitations by taking on part-time roles but working more hours than they were paid for, others by living with a constant feeling that they were not meeting the goals set for them, and others by pushing themselves to the extreme to meet the expectations of supervisors. However, it was also evident that managing their executive functioning challenges – while remaining model employees who consistently meet the demands of the role – significantly impacts their wellbeing.

Challenges include multitasking and managing executive function issues, so I stay organized and on task, otherwise I get quickly overwhelmed and stressed. Staying organized and on top of everything takes a huge amount of energy and I often come home exhausted, shutdown and nonverbal from the effort of socializing and organizing myself. (Trevor)

However, there are definite positives of academic work roles for autistic people. The cerebral aspects of the role serve as major attractions to, and benefits of, working in academia. These include the ability to focus on an area of interest and the more general intellectual components of the role. For those fortunate enough to be in research or teaching areas aligned with their interests, academia provides a rare environment where autistic special interests are seen as valuable expertise (rather than ‘weird obsessions’). The academic environment offers an opportunity to exercise many of the cognitive strengths of autistic people, including our intense focus, capacity to recognise patterns and ability to generate novel solutions. As Olivia reflected, ‘I feel that I am finally using my brain properly’. It also values personal characteristics that may be undervalued in other careers, such as perseverance, perfectionism and attention to detail.

I am being paid to conduct research that I am personally and professionally enamoured with. Call it a special interest or weird obsession or whatever other people may label it but for me there are some days I cannot believe I am as lucky as I am to be in the position I am in. (Flora)

We speak different languages

Participants identified communication in the workplace as a significant challenge, both understanding and being understood by others. Challenges in receptive communication included understanding questions from students and colleagues, understanding and following vague instructions from supervisors and following conversations with others. As with non-work interactions, these issues are exacerbated by the energy required to manage the sensory overload that accompanies interpersonal interactions, particularly in group settings. Challenges in expressive communication included difficulty finding the right words, expressions and tone of voice; being expected to respond spontaneously; knowing how to start and end conversations; and a frequent feeling that others don’t understand their communication.

... the many interactions required over a day or a week can be draining. I’m not so good at knowing how to end conversations, so I often let conversations go on much longer than my time or energy permits. (Marie)

Many of these communication issues stem from different ways of thinking and being in the neuro-minority in the workplace. Participants described complex, high-level internal thinking processes, including making links between seemingly unrelated concepts, visual thinking and being able to perceive and think in patterns. While these are common strengths of autistic brains (Crespi, 2021) and contribute to our ability to develop complex and novel solutions to problems, they can be difficult to explain to others. These differences in processing and communication styles also result in contributions being overlooked or dismissed, and a feeling of not being a valued team member.

Difficulties in written communication are also problematic for autistic people working in hierarchical university environments, particularly learning the nuances of correspondence such as emails and formal letters. These skills are perceived to be intuitive to non-autistic people, and there is often a lack of awareness that autistics may need additional support to learn these complex social rules.

Participants discussed being sensitive to criticism from others and being worn down by negative feedback from supervisors, colleagues or students. While recognising that this reaction to criticism was in part due to oversensitivity, participants also noted that there was often unfair criticism due to poor communication from others or a tendency to attribute problems to them with their autism seen as the ‘reason’ for problems arising. Several mentioned internalising this criticism and perseverating over how they may have contributed to the communication issues or negative outcomes.

I automatically take things to heart too quickly if I think that someone has criticised my work, particularly since I’m working my butt off and it’s unpaid. I’m consciously trying to make myself change that automatic response. ... (Ava)

Widespread lack of awareness of, and misunderstandings about, autism create challenges in the workplace. Many expend considerable emotional energy trying to correct these misperceptions but find themselves ignored or dismissed based on ‘learnings’ from media exposure or limited contact with autistic people. A common concern was the impact of others’ negative and dismissive comments about autism. Those who had disclosed experienced negative impacts due to ableist assumptions about their capacity, and those who had not disclosed by offhand insults about autism from people unaware of their diagnosis. These challenges were in some ways greater for those working specifically in autism research, with constant exposure to the literature that positions autism as a deficit and to practices that are harmful to autistic people.

... being an autistic autism researcher can be very hard. So much of the literature I have to read is, at best, incredibly ableist and, at worst, completely dehumanizing. People do not consider that I may be autistic when they meet me, and speak to me in ways that is often very upsetting and insulting about autism and autistic people. (Louise)

Intersectionality poses additional challenges, with participants experiencing offensive and demeaning commentary about multiple aspects of their identity. Issues of discrimination based on gender, race, sexuality and other characteristics are cumulative and contribute to feeling unwelcome or unsafe in academia. For some, this creates a hostile work environment that is both exhausting and damaging.

I also experienced enough antisemitism in my academic career to make me feel terribly isolated. One of the problems is that I was never sure if people hate me because I am autistic, or if they hate me because I’m Jewish. (Mia)

Conversely, participants reflected that academia presents opportunities for connection that enable us to utilise our strengths, be recognised as equals and participate in a meaningful way. The ability to connect over shared interests and goals provides a structure for social interaction and acknowledgement of our strengths rather than our challenges.

What I love about my job, weirdly enough, is the connection with people. I love sharing a special interest with someone and watching the lightbulb go off as they ‘get it’ and appreciate how fascinating it is. Shared fascination is like shared awe: a singular, bonding experience. (Saskia)

Senses working overdrive

Physical aspects of the work environment pose additional challenges for autistic academics, particularly those with sensory sensitivities. The most common concerns raised were bright lights, noise and air-conditioning. Several

participants commented that this constant sensory input led to sensory overload and meltdown.

I have sensory integration issues in classrooms and offices where bright lights are used. I also struggle with air-conditioners and find it difficult to maintain my composure when a room is too cold for me. (Trina)

Institutional policies exacerbate these sensory challenges; factors such as who is ‘entitled’ to an office, lack of awareness and willingness to make necessary environmental adjustments. It is noteworthy that several of these reflections came from participants who work in institutions that one would expect to be responsive to sensory issues, such as an autism-focused research and training centre. While many participants expressed frustration with the status quo, others seemed resigned to working in inappropriate conditions despite the cost to their wellbeing (and the minimal expense and effort it would require for organisations to address these issues).

And the office that they put me in for when I do go in to the office, pre-COVID, of course, it’s quite bright, and they thought they’d try and help by removing a light bulb above my desk, but that doesn’t really help. But it’s the thought that counts. And they also seated me next to, like in sort of a shared office, and there’s quite a bit of movement, which is quite distracting, but I guess they don’t. . . They didn’t really sort of think about that, I guess. And yeah, I’m only in there once a fortnight, so there’s no point in me making a fuss about it. (Charlotte)

However, the flexibility of many academic roles (discussed above) provides opportunities for autistic academics to have some degree of control over their physical work environment. While they may not be empowered to change the shared workplace, the ability to work from home or other locations can provide a welcome relief from sensory overstimulation.

I also like that my current roles are work-from-home (even prior to COVID-19), which suits me very well. I like being able to choose my own hours and work in my pyjamas with my cat on my lap, and I like not being exhausted from interacting with people at the end of each day. (Ella)

Discussion

Autism research conducted with autistic people, positioning those with lived experience as partners in research, is becoming the norm and the expectation in high-quality autism journals. However, much of this discussion still positions participatory research as linking two discrete groups of individuals: ‘autism researchers’ (non-autistic people with research training employed in academia) and ‘autistic individuals’ (non-research trained people with lived experience of autism). What is often missing from

the discussion is autism research conducted by autistic people – that is, autistic people working within universities and other research organisations.

An autistic autism researcher undertook this study, and participants were autistic researchers from a wide range of disciplines, many of whom undertake research and/or advocacy in autism. As noted in a roundtable discussion on the experiences of autistic autism researchers, ‘no academic articles focusing on autistic scholars in autism research currently exist in the literature’ (Dwyer et al., 2021). The findings of this study support those of the exploratory questionnaire study of 12 autistic academics in the United Kingdom (Martin, 2021).

This group of autistic people working in academia identified a range of challenges and frustrations of working in academia. They frequently raised aspects of social interaction, interpersonal communication, stigma and discrimination as causing tension within the workplace, as well as leading to anxiety and distress for the autistic employee. This is consistent with research into the employment experiences of autistic people in other work contexts. For example, a recent multi-country study found that stigma, communication challenges and a lack of understanding of autism were key barriers to successful employment for autistic adults (Black et al., 2020).

A recent survey of 249 autistic teachers in UK primary and secondary schools (Wood & Happé, 2021) identified the key challenges for that cohort as lack of (autism) understanding and support, including limited flexibility and work accommodations; sensory overload, change and unpredictability; mental health issues such as anxiety, fatigue and burnout; and the emotional toll of observing poor treatment of autistic pupils.

While academia is seen by many as a privileged and relaxed work environment, the reality of modern universities is increasing workloads and reduced job security (Cannizzo et al., 2019; Steenkamp & Roberts, 2020), to the extent that a healthy work-life balance is difficult to maintain (Cannizzo et al., 2019). The constant social interaction and the need to ‘fit in’ imposes pressure on autistic employees to mask aspects of their autism, which impacts physical and emotional wellbeing and career outcomes. While this is not unique to academia (North, 2021), it is exacerbated by the transient nature of social groups (such as student cohorts) and the complex dynamics between collaboration and competition.

I’ve started admitting I am autistic and wow – what a mixed bag that is. I have people who insist it is a mental illness, people who insist I am not and cannot be because their son is, to people who either pity me or shun me more. I abhor pity. I don’t at all care for being ostracized and shunned either. So communication is a challenge. The emotional work environment is hugely challenging. I never had such issues before, and am quite frankly traumatized by things that have happened to me here. So I am now alone. I never was alone before. (Isabella)

The competitive nature of academia, with its implicit motivators to withhold knowledge from others, is problematic even for neurotypical people (Hernaes et al., 2019) but is exacerbated for autistic academics who typically have fewer social networks. A recent study concluded that a competitive psychological climate is associated with high work engagement and career success for people with high leader-member exchange (strong relationships between employees and supervisors) but with burnout and lower career success for those with low leader-member exchange (Spurk et al., 2021).

Executive functioning challenges – including obtaining, retaining and processing information – were raised by participants as impacting their academic employment success. This is consistent with a recent study into employment experiences of autistic adults which found multi-directional associations between executive function, anxiety and work performance (Woolard et al., 2021). Academia is an information-rich, rapidly changing work environment with a constant need to juggle multiple tasks and perspectives, which poses significant challenges for people with limitations on their executive functioning and working memory (Habib et al., 2019). While aware of their executive functioning challenges and consciously putting in place strategies to address them, participants acknowledged that this constant effort significantly impacts their wellbeing.

Consistent with the UK survey of autistic teachers (Wood & Happé, 2021), the autistic academics in this study also commented on sensory issues related to the physical environment such as bright lights, noise and air-conditioning, and noted that these could be exacerbated by institutional policies and lack of awareness among employers and colleagues.

It was concerning to note the extent to which many participants accepted the challenges of working in academia as inevitable and/or requiring them to ‘try harder’ to navigate these challenges. As Martin et al. (2019) note, autistic employees can flourish in the workplace when provided with supportive working environments; employers need to be aware of, and willing to provide, the reasonable adjustments that autistic employees require to achieve their potential.

Conversely, participants identified significant benefits of academia as a career choice for autistic individuals. The life of an academic is one of deep engagement with areas of interest and where comprehensive knowledge of a specific topic is seen as a strength rather than an anomaly. Autistic strengths – such as intense focus, capacity to recognise patterns, ability to generate novel solutions, perseverance, perfectionism and attention to detail – can come to the fore in academia in a way that makes this an ideal profession for our neurotype. Also consistent with the findings of the UK teacher study (Wood & Happé, 2021), these academics noted that their ability to connect with and support students – particularly those experiencing marginalisation or disadvantage

– was both a strength and a benefit of this career choice. Academia provides a unique setting to utilise our enthusiasm for sharing our knowledge and providing others with a nurturing and supportive learning environment.

I like that my supervisor treats me as an equal and provides me with so many opportunities to learn and grow, I genuinely like the vast majority of my colleagues and what's not to love about working on one of your special interests day in and day out? In many respects, this is my ideal job. (Louise)

For those fortunate to have supportive colleagues and employers, and to work in an institution that understands and addresses the needs of autistic people, the life of an academic has many other positive aspects. These include flexibility in working style and location, autonomy and independence, predictable routines, visible measures of success, and good employment conditions. In addition, academia provides the opportunity to make a meaningful contribution to others – from teaching an individual student to researching solutions to world problems.

Conclusion

This study identified a number of challenges faced by autistic people working in academia across a range of countries and disciplines. Many of these challenges could be remediated by adjustments to the physical environment and workload, such as flexible working hours and work spaces that allow control over sensory input. Others demonstrate the need to educate supervisors and colleagues on how to work with and support autistic employees. Above all, creating safe and supportive work environments for autistic academics requires a greater understanding of the strengths of autistic people and acceptance of diversity in ways of working. Given the considerable benefits that autistic teachers and researchers bring to higher education, there is a clear need for universities and colleges to implement changes to the physical and social environment to make academia more inclusive.

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Supplemental material

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